

The counter to a rhetorical move is not a better one. It is a boring, specific question asked in an ordinary voice.

Somebody changed the subject and you did not notice for ten minutes. Somebody cited a study that does not exist. Somebody said “with respect” and then said something else entirely, and by the time you worked out what had happened, the room had moved on.

This is a catalogue of one hundred and forty-four ways an argument is won without being right. Each one is a line you would actually hear, the name of the move underneath it, why it works on people rather than why it is invalid, and something to say back.

The replies are deliberately unimpressive. Almost none of them are clever, because cleverness escalates and escalation is how you lose a room. Nearly all of them do the same two things: concede whatever is true, at once and without reluctance, then put the original question back on the table.

The Art of Being Right

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One hundred and forty-four ways an argument is won unfairly, and what to say back.

“So what you are saying is we should just do nothing.”

The Straw Man

WHAT TO SAY BACK Give the sentence, not the objection. What I am saying is we should do the first two and wait on the third. No indignation, no accusation.

144 MOVES · 12 CHAPTERS · 4 PARTS

